

New Investigations into the Primitive Family

[Nye Undersøgelser om den primitive Familje]

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New Investigations into the Primitive Family.

C. N. Starcke: Die primitive Familie in ihrer Entstehung und Entwicklung. Leipzig. F. A. Brockhaus. 1888. (Internationale wissenschaftliche Bibliothek. 66. Bind).

It will hardly surprise anyone that a philosophical author should occupy himself with investigations into the history of the family. If philosophy is to be something other and more than constructions proceeding from subjective consciousness, and if ethics in particular is to be something more than the setting up of postulates, then a factual material must be procured, and for ethics that means a historical material, one that can in many ways shed light on the worth of the principles and on the possibilities of their application. To be sure, a definite distinction must be drawn — at least in my view — between historical and philosophical ethics. The former can only present ethical life and ethical institutions as they have *in fact* developed under certain conditions; but a task different from that is their *valuation*, the assessment of their significance for the continued, conscious development of human life. Yet conscious intervention always presupposes possibilities of development and germs that have come into being spontaneously. Knowledge of the historical forms of life of the past is therefore a necessary condition for a fruitful treatment of ethics. And it is not always a given that historians and ethnologists arrange the material in the way philosophy needs it. That requires not only historical criticism but also a philosophical eye for the decisive points. Just as the history of law cannot do without the collaboration of the circle of jurists, so philosophical training will be a necessary presupposition for the treatment and presentation of historical ethics.

[788] In recent years special attention has been aroused by the primitive family, i.e. the family as it appears at the lowest stages of human development known to us. Whereas one formerly stopped at the patriarchal family as one knew it from the Old Testament narratives and from the Indian poems and law books, the significant step has now been taken that historical or comparative ethics also began to take account of the family relations of the savage peoples. It was now seen that one had no right to regard the Hebrew and Indian stage of development as the most primitive. There came here a revolution in thinking similar to the one when linguistics went beyond Sanskrit and took account of the languages of the savage nations, or when mythology brought the

religious representations of the savages within its purview. One came upon new and surprising facts and was thereby led to bold hypotheses. Dr. Starcke's work, which is built on an extraordinarily thorough knowledge of the available material, and which bears witness to critical ability and a sound psychological eye, will quite certainly come to occupy a considerable place in the literature on the interesting subject it treats. It disdains the outward attractions that for many might have lain in the piquant features and entertaining anecdotes which the subject and the sources offer in abundance. It is sober and strict in its form, but attractive and instructive for anyone who wishes to be oriented in the subject and to have guidance in taking a position toward the bold, often wild assertions and consequences to which the subject has given rise. — Let me try briefly to indicate what it is about and what position Dr. Starcke takes.

It has been noticed that among a great many peoples around the earth kinship is reckoned not through the father but through the mother, so that a man's nearest heirs are not his sons but his sister's children. This custom is found in all parts of the world. It was then natural to assume that there was a common cause of it. The great looseness and freedom in sexual matters that is likewise found among most savage peoples led people to think of the old maxim: *pater incertus, mater semper certa*. (One may be uncertain who the father is, but the mother is always certain). It was assumed that the original condition in sexual matters had been a complete unrestraint and a constant changing, an indiscriminate mating (promiscuity), which made it impossible to assign the children to particular fathers and compelled one to take the female line as the basis. The first to put forward the hypothesis that there had been a time when kinship was [789] reckoned through the woman, an arrangement that marked an advance by replacing or at any rate regulating promiscuity, was *Bachofen*, in his work "Das Mutterrecht. Eine Untermehung über die Gynaikokratie der alten Welt nach ihrer religiösen und rechtlichen Natur" (Stuttgart 1861). He connected the predominance of the female line in a certain period with a bold mythological theory and held that in this period woman had been highly esteemed, and that her dominion (the matriarchate) had had great significance for the history of culture by softening the mores and restraining the animal instincts. He believed he found a support for his theory in polyandry, the form of sexual cohabitation in which one woman is the wife of several men. He regarded it as a necessary intermediate form through which the human race has worked its way out of promiscuity and approached monogamy. — Among those who have set up similar theories, *Mc Lennan* and *Lubbock* must be named. These investigators proceed with greater criticism and less mysticism than Bachofen, and Mc Lennan in particular seeks

acutely to show how a good many mores and customs at higher stages of development, which would otherwise be inexplicable, can be understood as remnants (survivals) of the female line or of polyandry with promiscuity as background. Such customs are, e.g., the levirate, the custom that a man was obliged to marry his deceased brother's widow, in such a way that the children who sprang from this marriage were nevertheless reckoned as the deceased's children; and Niyoga, the custom that the husband (still among the Indians, the Spartans, indeed among the Germanic peoples of the Middle Ages) could leave his wife to other men and yet regarded the children thus begotten as his own.

On this theory the picture of the development of the human race, as regards the relation between man and woman, would to be sure round itself off in a clear and simple way. From an original unbound community (promiscuity) we would come to the legalized community (the female line and polyandry), and from there through the patriarchal family to monogamous marriage. This clarity and simplicity has probably exercised a seductive power over the investigators named. A development may well have taken place without its course being so easy to survey. And first and foremost the question remains whether the stages named can really be shown to be historically given forms of development, each of which has been dominant in its time.

[790] Dr. Starcke denies both that one can infer back from the female line to an original promiscuity, and that the female line itself has been as general as the theory in question asserts. He then seeks to show that the female line, where it prevails, may have arisen from different motives among the different peoples, and that likewise the other mores and customs that have been appealed to must be explained otherwise than according to the theory.

As regards the first point (the female line as proof of original promiscuity), the author might have mentioned that there are investigators who assume the generality of the female line at a certain stage and yet reject the assumption of a general promiscuity. Thus *Post* in his "Afrikanische Jurisprudenz. Ethnologisch-juridische Beiträge" (1887). This alone suggests that the two assumptions do not stand and fall together. But most important is the general consideration that Dr. Starcke puts forward and substantiates: that from the way in which kinship is reckoned no conclusion can be drawn as to the nature of marriage. The female line shows only that regard for the father is set aside, but the question of the reason for this still stands open. That it cannot (everywhere at least) have been that it was uncertain who was the father can be seen from the fact that the female line still to this day holds under conditions in which the father can very well be identified. The real reason will be discovered when we consider that the family at

primitive stages does not exist as an independent society, but only as part of the clan and of the tribe. The group to which the child at birth attaches and to which it is reckoned is the clan. The child had to be reckoned *either* to the father's *or* to the mother's clan, and for various reasons among many peoples it was reckoned to the mother's. But the family relation proper was not necessarily affected thereby. The father could stand in the tenderest relation to his children even if they were reckoned to the mother's clan, not to his, and the same held for the mother where the male line prevailed. The determination of kinship is thus a determination of clan, in which at primitive stages no regard is taken to the relation of procreation. If we assume that the man, by virtue of his physical strength, was originally the dominant one, and that women and children were regarded as his property, the development of the female line can be explained by the different conditions operating among different peoples. Among the American peoples (e.g. the Columbians) a connection can be traced between the development of the female line and the firmer formation of the clan. To the woman's clan are also reckoned the children [791] she bears, which from the first are so closely bound up with her; she is the property of her kin, and her children in turn cannot be separated from her. The woman's value as a slave, or at any rate as a help in work, must presumably be retained here; the clan would not renounce it because she entered into sexual union with a man of another clan. With men of her own clan she was forbidden, on account of the prevailing exogamy, to enter into union. Among the African peoples (e.g. the Bechuanas) the motive for the rise of the female line is to be sought in the prevailing polygamy in connection with the arrangement that each wife lives by herself, and that the children thus come to form a household together with the mother, in contrast to the other households, which together with them gathered around the common head of the patriarchal family. The position the child obtains in the patriarchal family will here depend essentially on the mother's rank and dignity. The sons bear their mothers' names as long as the father lives, and only after the father's death does the eldest son of the foremost wife enter into his position and name. The germ of the female line lies in the weight the mother's position has acquired. — For the rest, other conditions too will be of decisive significance. An agricultural people will have a tendency toward the female line, because the daughter there is of value as a worker; a cattle-raising people will have a tendency toward the male line, because there it will be advantageous to sell the daughter and get cattle instead. For at primitive stages woman is, after all, regarded essentially as a piece of property that is to be employed as advantageously as possible, and this view is followed both on the father's and on the husband's side.

Modern observers and investigators are — according to Dr. Starcke — too inclined to transfer their own feelings to the savages. For us the consciousness of being the child's physical origin, of its being the father's blood that flows in the child's veins, is a necessary component of the paternal feeling proper. But it is not so for the savage. His representations connect more by merely external connection than according to real causality. Visual representations are the dominant ones in all of us and are altogether determining for the savage, so that what he *sees together* (and only that) also for him *belongs together*. The clan lives together in its own part of the village, and the children live with their mother in her own hut. This spatial being-together becomes of great [792] significance for the development of the female line. And it also explains the remarkable phenomenon that the savage and the barbarian regards himself as father even where he *knows* that he is not the physical father. His wife's children are always his own children as well. Polyandry, levirate and Niyoga find their explanation easily and naturally in this way of thinking, without any need to postulate an original indiscriminate mating. Among the savages the paternal relation is predominantly a legal relation, not so much a blood relation.

Besides this important psychological factor there is yet another consideration which according to Dr. Starcke is of decisive significance for a correct conception of the family institutions of the savages. The looseness and unrestraint in sexual matters that is found among the savages has naturally struck observers and investigators, but has had too great an influence on their theories. Satisfaction of the sexual instinct plays a large role in the savage's life, but is also easy to attain, since no narrow bounds are set to it by the prevailing mores. But precisely for that reason the sexual relation to another individual does not, among the savages, become of great practical significance, does not become the basis of an institution. The family as an institution has therefore from the first and for long ages been ordered according to quite other considerations than the natural impulses themselves that bring man and woman together. Only gradually, as the life of representation develops and it is no longer merely the crude spatial representation that dominates consciousness, will the paternal relation be regarded essentially as a blood relation, and with that the demand of chastity on the woman within, and soon also before, marriage will be given; from the woman it will then also be extended to the man.

Dr. Starcke ought perhaps to have carried the interesting psychological consideration indicated here somewhat further. With higher spiritual development and the finer sense that follows from it for the unity and coherence of personal life, it will also become impossible to conceive the sexual instinct and its satisfaction as something that stands

without any connection with the whole of the rest of the personality's life. Through many fine threads this side of life hangs together with life's other sides. This shows itself especially in the fact that the satisfaction of the physical instinct is not the exclusive goal, but that this satisfaction stands as a good only when a deeper sympathy with another individual, joy and delight in that individual, thereby receives its seal and its expression. The sexual instinct then develops into the feeling of erotic love proper, and the physical [793] union into being a spiritual union as well.

People have often read too much romance into the savages and found in their less restrained sexual life the freedom which, it is thought, the feeling of erotic love lacks in civilized life. Dr. Starcke, on the other hand, perhaps reads too little romance into the savages. In his book the relation between man and woman at the primitive stages of development appears partly as a merely physical sexual relation, partly as a purely juridical and economic relation. It would have been of great interest if he had used his large material to investigate how far the feeling of erotic love can be demonstrated among primitive human beings, and what forms it takes. It would certainly have been shown thereby that the conditions are after all not quite so different as one might gather from Dr. Starcke's presentation. Just as it is a great misunderstanding to believe that the savages live a free and unbound life, since they are even greater slaves of traditions, ceremonies and rules than most civilized peoples, so it would also be a misunderstanding to assume that even the lowest human stage of life we now know presents no emotional phenomena at all akin to what we now (as distinct from the mere sexual instinct) call the feeling of erotic love. But it would certainly be shown that the connection between feeling and instinct is still closer among the savages than it needs to be where a higher spiritual development has taken place. The savage knows no lyric except as an incitement to action or as a means of reaching his goal. An author who has occupied himself with *one* significant side of the savages' spiritual life says: "If you ask an Indian for a love song, he will answer that a love potion works better. The savage is extraordinarily practical. His arts, mime and drawing, do not exist for art's own sake, but as means to a definite end, as methods by which he can attain something he desires. The young savage whom Kohl [a traveler in North America] knew put his trust in having a picture of himself and a picture of his beloved. The heart of the female picture he smeared with magic powder; this was, he said, a common custom, and to it were added elegiac or malicious songs and downright criminal incantations." (*Andrew Lang: Myth, Ritual and Religion*. London 1887).

The glaring contrast which the life of the savages nevertheless undeniably displays

[794] between the sexual instinct, appearing in more or less fleeting flare-ups, and the fixed, lasting forms for the life and development of the race, can only be overcome and reconciled through the healthy development of the feeling of erotic love. The wonderful thing about this feeling is its power to bind so many of life's forces around one center, to unite the most ideal and the most elementary in human nature, and at the same time its power to undergo metamorphoses through changing fortunes and periods of life. Without this richness and this power of transformation it would not deserve the eminent place that poetry has given it.

We have not yet come far beyond the standpoint of the savages as regards this side of life. This shows itself already in the fact that so many — both of the adherents of “free love” and of its opponents — at the word “marriage” think first and foremost of a union between man and woman entered into in legal or ecclesiastical form. This has turned much bitter strife into a battle over mere words and has diverted attention from the real main point, namely the possibility of faithfulness and inwardness and their significance in the relation between man and woman. —

In Dr. Starcke's view there is a great and decisive difference between the *position* of the family at primitive and at higher stages of development. He shows in a striking way that the family proper (the group of husband, wife and children) only at a higher civilization becomes an independent society, independent of clans and tribes. Among the savages the family exists only as part of the clan. This had to be so on account of the unceasing struggle for existence. The clan persists because association is necessary in this struggle; in the family, on the other hand, the goods fought for and acquired are enjoyed. The more, therefore, the struggle for physical existence recedes, the more will the clan lose in significance, and the family develop independently. In family life man comes to partake of an enjoyment of a different kind from that which arises from the satisfaction of physical instincts, namely “the moral enjoyment that life for and with others affords”. — But as regards the *motives* that found marriage, there is, according to Dr. Starcke, not, and (he thinks) there ought not to be, any decisive difference between primitive and properly human life. “We have seen,” he says toward the end of his book, “that it is originally no tender feeling, at least not love, that instills in the man the wish to

[795] marry, that primitive marriage, hard and dark like primitive life, springs from the most concrete and sober necessities. And still to this day that marriage is bad in which the erotic is the prominent element in the relation between the spouses. The common home, in which each of them has his task, and the common interest in having children and bringing them up, these were the two foundations on which marriage was originally

built. And from the sympathy that inevitably springs from the common interests there grows in turn the love that finally completes and consolidates marriage.” But will not precisely the feeling of erotic love more and more become a necessary presupposition for a man and a woman to be minded to build on those two foundations? And can it be dispensed with as a cement that holds together the building that is raised? That it, in order to work in this way, must undergo a whole process of development in relation to the given tasks and periods of life has already been suggested. —

Although I have missed in Dr. Starcke’s book something that in my eyes is significant, I nonetheless part from it with full recognition of the thoroughness and acuteness to which it bears witness. Only imperfectly have I been able in this review to suggest the wealth of individual investigations that the book contains. It has appeared in German because so specialized an investigation could not count on sufficiently many readers in our mother tongue. But this circumstance ought not to exclude the author from due recognition from his countrymen.

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